



UPSC CSE 2026

ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL FOUNDATION

TRIBAL INDIA



Nataraj Sir

7+ Years Experience

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TRIBAL INDIA

Paper 2

Handout - 1

Concept of Tribe: We often come across the word 'Tribe' in our daily life. We can also see the words like 'Adivasi' and 'Scheduled tribe' used in Newspapers and Media.

European Anthropologists used the term to refer to people who were "Primitive" or "Barbaric" or lived in **backward traditions that didn't have cultural advancements like 'art of writing'**.

- Since then the word tribe has evolved.
- Adivasi is a generic term in India.
- Tribal society is often referred to varyingly as 'primitive' society, folk society, simple society and preliterate society.
- **Anthropologically** speaking, a tribe is a social group. The members live in a common territory, common dialect, common ancestor and uniform social organization, use simple technology and possess cultural homogeneity.
 - **Eg:** Onge of Andaman Islands etc.

Definition of Tribe:

- **D.N.Majumdar** defines tribe as a social group with **territorial affiliation**, **endogamous** with **no specialization of functions** ruled by **tribal officers hereditary** or otherwise united in **language or dialect** recognizing **social distance** with other tribes or castes.
- According to **Imperial gazetteers of India**, tribe is a group of family which has a **common name**, whose members **speak a dialect**, reside in a **common area** and observe **taboo in marriage**, though in the beginning they would not have been observing this taboo.

Scheduled Tribes:

They are the communities which are **recognised by the constitution of India**.

- **Article 366(25)** of the constitution of India deals with the **definition of Scheduled Tribe**. It says, "Such Tribes or Tribal communities part of such a group; groups within such tribes or tribal communities as are deemed under **article 342**, to be scheduled tribes for the purpose of this constitution".

- **Article 342** - The **president** through **public notification** specifies the tribes or the tribal communities or groups within tribes or tribal communities shall be deemed to STs in relation to that of state.
- If a specific tribe or community is officially listed as a Scheduled Tribe for a state, they get certain benefits and protections according to the constitution. The President decides and announces this through public notifications.
- So, in simple terms, tribes are groups of people with common things, and Scheduled Tribes are officially recognized groups that get special treatment under the law in India.

Features of Tribal Life:

1. Geographical Isolation (S)

- Tribes often live in **remote and inaccessible areas**, away from cities and towns.
- They depend heavily on natural and forest resources for food, shelter, and livelihood.
- **Example:** The **Jarawa tribe** of the **Andaman Islands** lives in dense forest areas, maintaining minimal contact with the outside world.

2. Homogeneous Ethnic Group (H)

- Each tribe has a **distinct cultural identity**, including food habits, dress, customs, and beliefs.
- This cultural similarity fosters a **strong sense of unity and belonging**.
- **Example:** The **Bhil tribe** of **Rajasthan** shares common traditions, festivals, and rituals.

3. Definite Territory (T)

- Tribes usually inhabit a **specific geographical area** that defines their community boundaries.
- They share common surroundings and resources, forming a sense of territorial belonging.
- **Example:** The **Toda tribe** of the **Nilgiri Hills (Tamil Nadu)** occupies a defined territory linked to their pastoral traditions.

4. Common Language and Culture (L)

- Each tribe has its **own language, dialect, and cultural practices** that distinguish it from others.
- Language strengthens **internal communication and group identity**.
- **Example:** The **Gond tribe** of **central India** has its own language and rich folklore traditions.

5. Low Level of Technology

- Tribal communities often use **simple, traditional tools and techniques** in daily life.

- Their technology is closely tied to the **local environment and available resources**.
- **Example:** The **Baigas of Madhya Pradesh** use traditional digging sticks and bows for agriculture and hunting.

6. Low Literacy

- Many tribes have **limited access to education**, leading to lower literacy rates.
- However, there are exceptions among some tribal states with effective education programs.
- **Example:** **Mizoram**, a tribal-majority state, has high literacy, while tribes like the **Birhor of Jharkhand** show lower literacy levels.

7. Endogamous Marriage (E)

- Most tribes practice **endogamy**, preferring marriages within the same tribe to preserve cultural purity and identity.
- **Example:** The **Santhal tribe of West Bengal** follows endogamous marriage traditions.

8. Direct Personal Relationships

- Tribal societies are characterized by **close personal bonds** and **collective participation** in social, religious, and economic life.
- **Example:** The **Bonda tribe of Odisha** maintains strong communal ties through collective farming, rituals, and festivals.

9. Division of Labor by Age and Sex

- Work is distributed based on **age and gender**, ensuring social balance and cooperation.
- **Example:** Among the **Khasi tribe of Meghalaya**, men usually manage agriculture, while women engage in weaving and household work.

10. Governed by Customary Laws

- Tribes follow **traditional unwritten laws and customs** that regulate marriage, property, and conflict resolution.
- Disputes are settled by **community councils or tribal elders** through collective discussion.
- **Example:** The **Naga tribes of Nagaland** practice self-governance through customary laws and village councils.

Tribe Vs Scheduled Tribe:

The Indian constitution only states that STs are specified by the **president after consultation with the Governor**; it does not specify specific criteria.

- According to the **Lokur Committee**, the Criteria while not spelled out in legislation- "is well established", and includes indication of
 - Primitive traits, *P* *BDS PG*
 - Distinctive culture, *D*
 - Geographical isolation, *G*
 - Shyness of contact with the community at large and *S*
 - Backwardness. *(B)*
- Analysis: However more than half a century later these **broad criteria leave a lot of discretion.**
 - In order to **avail the protections and benefits** of being accorded ST status, **communities in India try to prove themselves as meeting the criteria.**
 - Eg: Narikuravar** (studied by *Dr. Jagomir*)
 - The case of the **Narikuravar community** highlights the challenges faced by groups seeking **Scheduled Tribe (ST) status**. Despite their **nomadic lifestyle** and **social marginalization**, their active interaction with wider society made it difficult to meet traditional criteria such as **geographical isolation** and **shyness of contact**. This mismatch delayed their recognition, leading to **poor living conditions**, **limited access to government benefits**, and continued **social exclusion**. After a long struggle, the Narikuravars were finally granted **Scheduled Tribe status in 2023**, reflecting the **complexities of defining and recognizing tribal identity** in India's diverse social landscape.

CLASSIFICATION OF TRIBES:

- India is the abode to many tribal communities
- They live in different **social, economic and geographical situations.**
- Tribes are classified on the basis of different criteria
 - Territorial distribution
 - Racial affinity
 - Occupation specialization

- Linguistic affiliation

1) **Territorial distribution:** The tribe can be distinguished into five regions grouping based on ecological, social, economic, administrative and ethnic factors.

Classification:

1. North/North - Eastern zone
2. Central/Middle Zone
3. Southern zone
4. Island zone

1. **North/North - Eastern zone:** This zone includes North Eastern states like Assam, Manipur, Tripura, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Sikkim.

Ex: Nagas, Garo, Khasi, Lepchas (Sikkim), Kuki, Toto (West Bengal)

2. **Central/Middle Zone:** This zone includes states like U.P, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Bihar.

Ex: Mundas, Santhals, Baiga, Oraons, Ho, Birhor.

3. **Southern zone:** It comprises of Kerala, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana

Ex: Irulas, Kotas(Nilgiris), Todas, Yerukula, Yanadi, Chenchu, Kurumbas, Koyas

4. **Island zone:** It consists of Andaman And Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep.

Ex: Onge in Andaman and Nicobar, Sentinelese.

- Out of these 4, the **first three** are given by **B.S.Guha**. Whereas the **fourth one is a later addition.**

2) **Racial affinity/Bio-genetic Variability:**

- On the basis of **physical characteristics** the tribes in India are classified into **four racial groups** namely:

1. Negrito
2. Proto australoid
3. Mongoloid
4. Other groups

1. **Negrito:**

- The Negrito races are characterized by short or medium physical stature, dark brown skin color, flat and broad nose, thick lips and wooly hair.

Ex: Onge, Jarawa, Sentinelese, Great Andamanese.

2. **Proto australoid group:**

- Most of the tribal population of India belong to this Racial group.
- They are characterized by medium stature, dark skin color, curly hair, low forehead. Some scholars called them pre-Dravidian.
- These people exhibit strong muscular build bodies.
 - **Ex:** Chenchu, Koya, Yerukula, Gonds, Santhals.

3. **Mongoloid group:**

- The tribes of the North-east frontier area exhibit mongoloid characters.
- Their stature is medium, skin color is yellowish brown and the face is flat with prominent cheekbones.
- The nose is also flat and eye-slit is oblique with epicanthic fold.
- The hair is straight but the hair growth is minimal on the body and face.
 - **Ex:** Garo, Kuki, Naga.

4. **Other groups:**

- The Mediterranean
 - Paleo Mediterranean
 - Mediterranean
 - Oriental type
- Western brachycephals
 - Alpinoid
 - Dinaric
 - Armenoid
- Nordic
- This category includes tribes that do not fit neatly into the Negrito, Proto Australoid, or Mongoloid classifications. It reflects the diversity and unique physical characteristics of certain tribal communities.

BIO-GENETIC VARIABILITY:

Bio-genetic variability refers to the genetic differences observed among human populations, arising due to the **interaction between genes and environment**. When specific genes occur in particular environments and interact with one another, they produce **variability** in biological traits such as **blood groups, hemoglobin types, and physical features**.

In tribal populations, this variability **reflects long-term evolutionary processes**, **isolation**, **migration**, and **adaptation** to diverse ecological zones across India.

Scholarly Studies and Findings:

(a) **Risley, Guha, and Sarkar:** (Refer to Racial/Ethnic Classification Handout from Indian Society module)

(b) **Majumdar** et al. (mtDNA Study)

- Analyzed mtDNA across 115 individuals from different linguistic groups.
- Finding: Austro-Asiatic tribes** showed greater genetic diversity than **Dravidian tribes**, indicating older ancestry.

(c) **Bhasin** et al. (1985) - *Ethnic Group Differences in Surat District*

- Analyzed tribes like **Vasava** and **Kotwalia** in Gujarat.
- Finding:** No major genetic difference within the same ethnic group living in the same region, confirming **regional homogeneity** due to endogamy.

(d) **Blake** et al. (1981) - *Geographical Proximity Study*

- Examined 11 major tribal groups of **Andhra Pradesh** such as **Chenchus** and **Pradhans**.
- Finding:** Tribes located geographically close to each other shared **genetic similarities**, confirming **regional gene flow**.

Bio-genetic variability in tribal populations highlights the rich **genetic mosaic of India**. Understanding such diversity helps anthropologists trace **human evolution, disease patterns, and adaptation strategies**, reinforcing the view that Indian tribes represent a **living laboratory of human genetic variation**.

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